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BACKGROUND GUIDE

AGENDA:

“Reviewing deeds and destinies in Chitragupta's court”

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Message from the Executive Board

Esteemed Delegates,

Welcome to **Dharamkshetra: Chitrugupta's Court** at **BITSMUN 2025** — a unique simulation where the divine and the mortal realms converge and where every deed, every word, and every decision echoes through the cosmic balance of Dharma and Karma.

In this committee, you are tasked with revisiting the eternal question: *What truly determines the destiny of a soul?* As cosmic arbiters, you will review, debate, and challenge the fates of mortals based on their karmic records. The agenda before you — **“Reviewing Deeds and Destinies in Chitrugupta's Court”** — invites not only theological and philosophical inquiry but demands a creative exploration of justice, morality, and cosmic law. Inspired by the epics, especially the **Mahabharata**, this committee will integrate **unique crisis mechanics**, including divine interventions, karmic freezes, and boons that will test your strategic thinking and understanding of the ancient moral fabric.

This **Background Guide** is intended to provide you with a starting point. However, it is by no means exhaustive. We strongly encourage every delegate to dive deeper — explore scriptures, mythological stories, philosophical treatises, and even modern interpretations of dharma and karma. Your arguments, creativity, and understanding of these concepts will shape this committee far more than eloquence or oratory skills.

We look forward to witnessing **dynamic debates, ethical dilemmas, and philosophical showdowns** as you navigate through this cosmic courtroom. We are certain this committee will be as much a learning experience for us as it is for you. Should you have any questions or require clarification, feel free to reach out to us. We are always available to guide you on this journey.

All the best, and may Dharma guide your path!

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Introduction

The Historical and Philosophical Landscape of Chitragupta's Court

The concept of divine judgment, as envisioned in Hindu philosophy, offers a fascinating blend of legalism, morality, and cosmic order. At its heart is Chitragupta, the celestial scribe entrusted with maintaining an impartial record of human actions. Unlike the Western notion of an omnipotent deity dispensing unilateral verdicts, Hinduism presents a more intricate model where justice results from accumulated karma rather than divine whim.

Chitragupta's role is deeply embedded in Dharmic traditions, where justice is punitive and corrective. His records serve as the cosmic blueprint for an individual's rebirth, charting their journey through samsara (the cycle of birth and rebirth) or, in rare cases, moksha (liberation). The meticulous nature of his documentation implies a deterministic worldview, yet Hindu scriptures also introduce the possibility of free will, atonement (prayaschitta), and divine intervention altering one's fate.

Historically, notions of posthumous judgment appear across Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain traditions, each interpreting the consequences of karma differently. The Garuda Purana describes vivid accounts of Naraka (hell), where souls undergo punishments befitting their misdeeds, reminiscent of the moral cause-and-effect principles in ancient Indian jurisprudence. In contrast, texts like the Bhagavad Gita and Upanishads emphasize self-realization, implying that ultimate justice is not merely about reward or punishment but about spiritual evolution.

This committee, Dharamkshetra, will function as a cosmic tribunal, seeking to adjudicate moral dilemmas based on theological, philosophical, and logical perspectives. Delegates will step into the shoes of celestial jurists, examining past and present karmic records, debating the fairness of eternal damnation versus corrective justice, and questioning whether karma can be overridden through repentance or divine grace.

Mandate of the Committee

In the divine court of **Chitragupta**, the celestial scribe and keeper of mortal records, this committee gathers to review the deeds and destinies of beings caught between the forces of **karma (action)** and **bhagya (destiny)**. Delegates, assuming the roles of gods, sages, warriors, and other mythological figures, will navigate the delicate balance between free will, divine justice, and cosmic order.

The committee's primary purpose is to examine **pivotal moments frozen in time**, drawn exclusively from the epic of **Mahabharata** — moments that shaped the fates of empires, kings, and the very dharma of the cosmos. In these frozen junctures, delegates will deliberate on whether justice was truly served, whether destiny was inevitable, and how the scales of divine judgment tilted.

The central questions that shall guide this court are:

- Can destiny be rewritten by righteous deeds?
- How should justice account for human flaws, divine will, and the complexities of circumstance?
- What is the true measure of a deed—its intent, its outcome, or its impact on the cosmos?

This committee challenges delegates to step into the shoes of divine arbiters, weighing the weight of actions against the tapestry of fate. By examining these frozen moments, delegates will not only pass judgment on the past but also explore the timeless principles of dharma, justice, and cosmic balance.

The Time Freeze Mechanic

This committee introduces a unique **Time Freeze Mechanic**, where debates will revolve around critical "frozen moments" exclusively from the **Mahabharata**. These frozen moments represent monumental events — the roll of the dice, Draupadi's humiliation, Krishna's counsel, Karna's death, and more — where the course of history, dharma, and karma could have altered forever.

Within these freezes, delegates will:

- **Analyze the Deeds:** Examine the actions taken by individuals in these moments—were they driven by dharma, ambition, or circumstance?
- **Evaluate the Consequences:** Assess the outcomes of these deeds—were they just, unjust, or inevitable?
- **Question Destiny:** Reflect on whether destiny could have been altered—was there a path not taken, or was fate sealed from the start?

Each moment will be presented by the Executive Board, setting the stage for deep philosophical and moral debate. Delegates may invoke **divine boons**, appeal to cosmic laws, or propose alternative courses of action — but every judgment must respect the interplay of **karma**, **dharma**, and **fate** as enshrined in the Mahabharata.

Example of a Frozen Moment

The Gambling Match of Yudhishtira

Deeds: Yudhishtira's decision to gamble away his kingdom, his brothers, and himself.

Consequences: The Pandavas' exile, Draupadi's humiliation, and the seeds of the Kurukshetra war.

Destiny: Was this moment a test of Yudhishtira's dharma, or was it an inevitable step toward the greater cosmic plan?

Delegates will debate whether Yudhishtira's actions were just, whether the consequences were deserved, and whether destiny could have been altered.

Understanding the Core Concepts

1. Dharma: Righteous Duty and Moral Obligation

Dharma is the fundamental principle that governs righteous action and moral obligation. In the Mahabharata, the idea of dharma is layered and often conflicting—what is right for an individual (svadharma) may contradict what is right for society or the cosmos (sanatana dharma). Dharma becomes situational, demanding introspection and wise judgment. Delegates must understand that dharma is not absolute but fluid, reflecting the complex ethical landscape of the epic and this committee. Every frozen moment debated will test whether actions aligned with one's dharma or deviated under pressure, fear, or desire.

For example:

- Yudhishtira's Dharma: His adherence to truth and righteousness often conflicts with his duty as a king and brother.
- Karna's Dharma: His loyalty to Duryodhana clashes with his innate sense of justice and morality.

Dharma is not just about following rules but about understanding the deeper purpose behind actions. Delegates must ask:

- Was the action in alignment with the individual's dharma?
- How does one balance personal duty with universal morality?
- Can deviation from dharma ever be justified?

2. Karma (Actions and Consequences)

Karma refers to the principle of cause and effect, where every action generates consequences, both immediate and cosmic. In the Mahabharata, karma operates not just on actions but also on intent, making it a central lens for analyzing justice. Characters often face unintended results of their deeds, raising questions about whether morality is judged by intention or outcome. Delegates must delve into this

concept to debate if the characters' karmic burden justified their fate or if cosmic justice was skewed.

- Key aspects of karma include:
- Sanchita Karma: The accumulated karma from past lives.
- Prarabdha Karma: The portion of karma being experienced in the present life.
- Kriyamana Karma: The karma being created through current actions.

For example:

- Karna's Karma: Despite his noble intentions, his past actions and curses lead to his tragic fate.
- Draupadi's Karma: Her suffering is often attributed to her past-life actions, raising questions about the fairness of karma.

Delegates must consider:

- How do past actions influence present circumstances?
- Can present actions mitigate or amplify the effects of past karma?
- Is destiny merely the unfolding of accumulated karma, or is there room for free will?

3. Bhagya (Destiny) and the Concept of Free Will

Bhagya, or destiny, is another critical concept shaping the Mahabharata's narrative. Events seem preordained by divine will or curses, yet characters continue to struggle, hinting at free will's role in altering fate. This duality will shape committee debates—was destiny inevitable, or could the characters have chosen differently? Delegates will explore whether righteous deeds can indeed rewrite destiny or if some fates are unchangeable, testing the limits of cosmic justice.

For example:

- The Pandavas' Exile: Was their suffering a result of destiny, or could Yudhishtira have avoided the gambling match?

- Karna's Death: Was his fate sealed by his loyalty to Duryodhana, or could he have chosen a different path?

Delegates must ask:

- Can destiny be altered by righteous actions?
- How does divine intervention influence the course of destiny?
- Is it just for individuals to suffer due to actions they do not remember (past-life karma)?

4. Swarga (Heaven) and Naraka (Hell)

In Sanatan Dharma, Swarga (heaven) and Narka (hell) are temporary realms where souls experience the fruits of their karma. These realms are not eternal destinations but rather stages in the soul's journey through the cycle of birth and death (samsara).

Swarga: Swarga is a realm of pleasure and reward, where souls enjoy the benefits of their virtuous deeds (punya). It is often depicted as a place of beauty, abundance, and divine bliss, inhabited by gods (devas) and other celestial beings. However, Swarga is not the ultimate goal; it is a temporary respite where souls reap the rewards of their good karma before returning to the cycle of rebirth.

Narka: Narka, on the other hand, is a realm of suffering and punishment, where souls face the consequences of their sinful actions (paap). It is described as a place of torment, where souls undergo trials to purify themselves of their negative karma. Like Swarga, Narka is not permanent; it serves as a corrective mechanism to balance the soul's karmic account before it is reborn.

The concepts of Swarga and Narka reflect the principles of cosmic justice, where every action has a corresponding consequence. They emphasize the idea that moral and ethical behavior is rewarded, while wrongdoing is punished, ensuring a balance in the universe. However, both realms are part of the larger cycle of samsara, and the ultimate goal is to transcend these temporary states and achieve moksha (liberation).

6. Reincarnation (Punarjanma)

Reincarnation or **Punarjanma** is the continuous cycle of birth, death, and rebirth governed by the law of karma. A soul is reborn repeatedly until it attains moksha, carrying forward the unresolved karmic balance—both good and bad—from its past lives. The Mahabharata frequently portrays characters bound by these past deeds, often suffering or reaping rewards due to actions committed in previous births. This cyclical nature ensures that no karma is ever lost; every action eventually finds its consequence, even across lifetimes. Delegates must understand that reincarnation complicates the idea of justice, as suffering or fortune in a character's current life may stem from deeds in a life long forgotten. Thus, the court's judgments must account for this unseen karmic inheritance while deciding the fate of souls.

7. Moksha (Liberation) and Cosmic Balance

Moksha, or liberation from the cycle of birth and death, represents the ultimate goal in Hindu philosophy. The Mahabharata continuously circles back to this idea—can a life lived righteously, or perhaps a final redemptive act, grant moksha? Delegates must analyze whether the characters achieved balance or continued the cycle of karma. Through this lens, the committee explores not just judgment but also the philosophical endpoint of every soul—freedom or further entanglement in the karmic web.

Chitragupta: The Divine Scribe

Amidst the vast Hindu pantheon, **Chitragupta** holds a distinct yet often forgotten role — that of the celestial scribe and keeper of karma. Unlike gods engaged in cosmic battles or incarnations, Chitragupta's power lies in observation, impartial judgment, and meticulous record-keeping, making him central to the very concept of cosmic justice.

Mythological Origins and Significance

According to Hindu scriptures, Chitragupta was created by **Lord Brahma** from his mind and body — symbolizing intellect and physical reality. Tasked alongside **Yamraj**, the God of Death and Dharma, Chitragupta maintains the **ledger of karma** — recording every good deed (*punya*) and sin (*paap*) committed by mortals.

His name reflects his function: *Chitra* meaning "picture" or "portrait," and *Gupta* meaning "hidden" or "secret." Chitragupta silently creates the hidden portrait of every soul's actions, ensuring that no deed, however secret, escapes divine accounting.

Role in Sanatan Dharma's Justice System

In Sanatan Dharma, justice is impartial and thorough. Upon death, every soul stands before **Yama's court**, where Chitragupta presents their karmic record. Based on this unbiased account, the soul faces reward in **Swarga (heaven)**, punishment in **Naraka (hell)**, or rebirth in **samsara**.

Chitragupta represents divine bureaucracy — where even kings and beggars are equal before karma's scrolls. His records form the foundation of cosmic justice, beyond emotion or divine favor.

Relevance to Mahabharata and the Committee

Though absent as a character, Chitragupta's influence pervades the **Mahabharata**, where karma, dharma, and sin shape destinies. Each act — from Draupadi's humiliation to Karna's fatal choices — contributes to the celestial record.

In **Dharamkshetra: Chitragupta's Court**, delegates embody this divine system. Tasked with revisiting key moments from the Mahabharata, the committee re-examines blurred lines of dharma and adharma. Like Chitragupta, delegates must act as impartial arbiters — questioning whether cosmic justice was truly served.

Yamraj & Yamdoot

Yamraj – The Cosmic Judge and Enforcer of Dharma

One of Sanatan Dharma's most revered gods, Yamraj is the God of Death, Dharma, and Justice. Responsible for maintaining the universal order, Yamraj is the king of Yamaloka, the divine court where every soul is tried after death. It is here that Chitragupta presents his meticulous accounts, and Yamraj delivers verdicts on the basis of the balance of karma — dispatching souls to Swarga (paradise), Naraka (hell), or the cycle of birth.

Yamraj is the embodiment of moral judgment and objectivity, beyond man's fear or awe. His role is not to punish but to maintain dharma by ensuring that actions, whether intentional or not, are rewarded with the right consequences. As the heavenly judge, Yamraj is a reminder that no action can go unnoticed by God.

In the Mahabharata, the character of Yamraj is embodied in his various avatars, the most significant of these being that of Dharma Raja, Yudhishtira's heavenly father. His lectures on duty, righteousness, and honesty provide the ethos of the epic. Yamraj's presence here symbolizes the incarnation of divine justice, with every utterance challenging the fairness and righteousness of what has transpired in the past.

Yamdoot – The Harbingers of Death and Justice

The Yamdoots are Yama's messengers in the heavenly realm, charged with the sacred responsibility of extracting souls from the mortal realm and presenting them to the cosmic court. They are impartial custodians of dharma, unconcerned by human sentiments, desires, or affinities. However terrifying they may be to humans, the

Yamdoots are not personifications of malice; they are agents of order, who bring every living thing to its reckoning according to its karma. Though appearances of the Yamdoots in the Mahabharata are discreet, they always inspire the awareness of mortality and the inevitability of divine retribution. Within the committee framework, they embody the relentless enforcement of cosmic justice—silent observers to every action, whether virtuous or hurtful.

Mythological and Scriptural References

The committee draws heavily upon a huge body of Hindu scripture, epic literature, and Puranic literature that underlies the vision of Sanatan Dharma with respect to such concepts as karma, dharma, cosmic justice, and divine judgment. These quotations represent the philosophical foundations of Dharamkshetra: Chitrugupta's Court, grounding all argument in available mythology and scriptural tradition. These are the key texts and how they connect with the committee's mission.

Garuda Purana

The Garuda Purana is identified as one of the most detailed texts explaining the post-mortem process of the soul. It provides a detailed account of Chitrugupta's role as the divine scribe, noting his meticulous recording of human deeds. The Purana also describes the process of adjudication in Yama's court, where souls are evaluated according to their accumulated karma. It also describes the domains of Swarga (heaven) and Naraka (hell) as destinations for souls based on their deeds. The Garuda Purana's lengthy descriptions of the karmic accounting system are used to inform the structural framework of this committee, thus establishing a clear method for the assessment of deeds and fates.

Mahabharata

The Mahabharata is the conceptual guide of the committee. Although Chitrugupta's direct influence on the epic is limited, the work heavily depends on the complex interplay between dharma, karma, and fate. The actions of the main

characters—Yudhishtira's rigid adherence to truth, Karna's tragic dilemma between loyalty and justice, and Draupadi's shame—raise important ethical issues that the committee shall critically reconsider. The epic also indirectly refers to the idea of divine justice through Yudhishtira's encounter with Dharma in the form of a Yaksha. These stories are rich case studies for the committee to consider, offering timeless lessons on morality and justice.

Manusmriti (The Laws of Manu)

The Manusmriti, being one of the oldest and most revered Dharmaśāstra texts, prescribes the codes and ethics of conduct that regulate human action. It gives a systematic classification of sins (paap) and their consequences, and also guidelines for moral living (dharmic conduct). The Manusmriti is a valuable key to understanding the committee's legal and ethical context and gives a systematic approach to evaluating the morality of action and the consequences that they result in.

Bhagavad Gita

The Bhagavad Gita, a core Hindu philosophical work, presents profound insight into the ideas of dharma, karma, and moksha. In his conversation with Arjuna, Lord Krishna emphasizes the need to fulfill one's duty without attachment to results, a principle which is at the core of the committee's mission. The Gita also speaks of the dynamic tension between personal duty and overall moral rightness, of the constant struggle between purpose and action. The principles set out in this book will probably shed light on committee debate, leading delegates through moral nuance and divine justice.

Yama Samhita

The Yama Samhita is a lesser-known but important text that discusses the role of Yama, the god of justice and death. It provides colorful descriptions of the karmic penalties that the souls undergo in the afterlife and discusses the role of Chitragupta in assisting Yama in the adjudication process.

Procedural Framework for Deliberation

The session will begin with **Roll Call** wherein you have to mark your presence. **Remember**, there is **no concept of PRESENT AND VOTING** in this forum.

Opening Statements

Post the roll call, the committee will enter into the round of **Opening Statements**. The default time for opening statements shall be **90 seconds**.

Opening statements are speeches which are used to clarify your stance on the agenda at hand. They are recommended to be given by everyone, though not obligatory. **Opening statements will be done at once, unlike the GSL which never exhausts.**

Sessions

Post the opening statements, we shall be establishing the following sessions:

- **Moderated Session**
- **Unmoderated Session**

For a moderated session, I would recommend you people to **decide the sub-agendas beforehand** so that we do not waste time in forming a consensus via unmoderated session and voting.

- **Moderated sessions** will be used to discuss sub-agendas pertaining to the main agenda.
- **Unmoderated session** will be a lobbying session.

How will you be recognized?

In order to get recognized, you have to **hold your placard high** and your **portfolio should be visible** to the EB.

Points

All four points will be considered in the forum:

- **Personal Privilege** – any audibility or clarity issue – to be raised verbally.
- **Enquiry** – any question from the executive board – to be raised via writing in the **Chit** or verbally.
- **Order** – any factual error correction – to be raised via writing in the **Chit** or verbally.
- **Information** – any question in context of the speech – may be verbal (if recognized) or written in the format:

Additional Procedural Notes

- **Right to/of reply** can also be sought, verbally after the speeches.
- **POIs (verbal)** will be entertained in the **moderated sessions**.
- **Opening statements will have a mandatory POI (verbal)**.
- **Equal recognition** will be ensured.
- **Substantive intervention** on the discretion of the participating members.
- Try **not speaking out your name/point when you are being recognized**, just raise your placard so as to avoid chaos.
- **Average marking** will be done in respect of replies to POI chits since it's not mandatory that everyone gets a POI chit.

References, Bibliography, and Suggested Reads

Primary Texts & Scriptures

1. **The Mahabharata**, translated by C. Rajagopalachari
Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan
 [Mahabharata by C. Rajagopalachari \(PDF\)](#)
2. **The Bhagavad Gita**, translated by Eknath Easwaran
Nilgiri Press
 Bhagavad Gita by Eknath Easwaran (PDF)
 [Overview: Bhagavad Gita Online – The Bhagavad Gita in English](#)
3. **The Manusmriti (Laws of Manu)**, translated by G. Buhler
Sacred Books of the East, Volume 25
 [Manusmriti by G. Buhler \(PDF\)](#)

Academic and Scholarly Resources

4. **Hindu Concepts of Justice: Dharma, Karma, and Moksha** — *Journal Article* (JSTOR)
 [Hindu Concepts of Justice \(JSTOR\)](#)
Note: Access via institution/library or JSTOR's free registration.
5. **The Hindus: An Alternative History** by Wendy Doniger
Penguin Books
 The Hindus on Amazon
 [The Hindus: PDF Version \(Archive.org\)](#)
6. **Indian Philosophy Volume 1 & 2** by S. Radhakrishnan
Oxford University Press
 [Indian Philosophy Vol. 1 \(PDF\)](#)
 [Indian Philosophy Vol. 2 \(PDF\)](#)

7. **Hindu Goddesses: Visions of the Divine Feminine** by David Kinsley

University of California Press

 [Hindu Goddesses on Amazon](#)

 [PDF Version \(Archive.org\)](#)

8. **Philosophies of India** by Heinrich Zimmer

Princeton University Press

 [Philosophies of India \(PDF\)](#)

